

Halogric Research Integration Series

MAPUCHE

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*Chile and Argentina -- The People Who Resisted the Inca and the Spanish, the Machi Healer,
and the Sacred Kultrun*

The Mapuche resisted the Inca Empire.

They resisted three centuries of Spanish colonization.

*Ixofill Mogen -- the sacredness of all living things --
was never a philosophy. It was always the operating principle.*

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Mapuche Sovereignty

The Mapuche people are a living nation with contemporary political claims, ongoing cultural practices, and specific decisions about what sacred knowledge is appropriate to share publicly. This document draws on what Mapuche scholars, cultural representatives, and anthropologists working in collaboration with Mapuche communities have published. Restricted ceremonial content is not included. The Mapuche people's sovereignty over their sacred knowledge and their political territory is honored.

Introduction -- The People of the Land: History and Identity

The Mapuche (from the Mapudungun words mapu -- earth/land -- and che -- people: literally people of the land) are the largest Indigenous people of Chile, with a contemporary population of approximately 1.7 million in Chile and an additional 200,000 in Argentina. They are also the most politically active and most culturally resilient Indigenous people in South America -- a people whose history of resistance against successive imperial powers, from the Inca Empire through Spanish colonization to the Chilean and Argentine states, constitutes one of the most extraordinary records of Indigenous perseverance in the Western Hemisphere. The machi's kultrun drum has not stopped.

Who the Mapuche Are -- Identity, Language, and Territory

The Mapuche people have inhabited the south-central zone of present-day Chile and Argentina since before historical documentation -- their territory (Wallmapu) stretching from the Bio-Bio River in the north to Patagonia in the south. The Mapudungun language (the people's tongue) belongs to its own language family with no demonstrated relatives -- a linguistic isolate that reflects the Mapuche's deep-time presence in their territory, similar to Basque in Europe and Tonkawa in North America. Approximately 20% of Mapuche people speak Mapudungun today; the language is classified as endangered. Mapuche social organization is organized around the lof (basic community unit), the rewe (ceremonial community), and the aillarehue (confederation of rewe groups) -- horizontal structures of relationship and reciprocity rather than hierarchical command. The lonko (head, chief) is the political leader; the machi is the sacred specialist; neither role is hereditary in the strict sense.

The Mapuche Resistance -- Inca, Spanish, and Republican

The Inca resistance: When the Inca Empire expanded southward through Chile in the late 15th century under Sapa Inca Tupac Yupanqui, they encountered in the Mapuche a people they could not subjugate. The Inca advance was stopped at the Bio-Bio River -- the Mapuche fighting forces proved sufficiently effective that the Inca established a defensive frontier rather than attempting conquest. The Inca at this point controlled the largest empire in the Americas. The Mapuche stopped them.

The Arauco War (1536-1818): Spanish colonization of Chile began in 1536. The war between the Spanish colonial forces and the Mapuche -- the Guerra de Arauco -- lasted for 282 years, making it one of the longest colonial wars in history. The Mapuche adopted Spanish military technology (horses, metal weapons) with extraordinary speed, turning these instruments against their colonizers. The Spanish were never able to establish stable control south of the Bio-Bio River. The Mapuche and Spain ultimately signed a series of parlamento (parliament) peace agreements -- formal diplomatic negotiations between sovereign entities -- acknowledging Mapuche political autonomy south of the Bio-Bio.

The Pacification of Araucania (1861-1883): The newly independent Chilean state achieved what the Spanish never did -- the military conquest of Mapuche territory -- through a sustained campaign that dispossessed the Mapuche of approximately 90% of their territory. The wounds of this dispossession are the direct context of the contemporary Mapuche political movement.

Mapuche Cosmology -- The Layered World

Mapuche cosmology describes a structured universe of multiple interpenetrating dimensions: the Wenu Mapu (the upper world, where Ngenechen and the beneficial spirits dwell), the Nag Mapu (the earth, the world of human beings), and the Minche Mapu (the world below, associated with dangerous forces and the dead in transit). Some traditions add additional layers. The three-world structure is universal in shamanic traditions -- the Bon tradition of Tibet, the Slavic tradition, the Norse tradition, the Alabama-Coushatta tradition all share this basic architecture, each with their own specific contents and their own specific sacred ecology within each layer.

Ngenechen -- The Sacred Creator

Ngenechen is the supreme divine being of the Mapuche -- ngen meaning owner or guardian, chen meaning people. Ngenechen is conceived as a four-part entity: an old man, an old woman, a young man, and a young woman -- the four faces of the divine expressing the sacred balance of male and female, age and youth that constitutes cosmic completeness. This fourfold divine character is the most distinctive element of Mapuche theology -- unlike traditions organized around a single divine person or a gendered divine pair, the Mapuche supreme being is already a community, already a balance of complementary energies.

HALIGRIC LENS: Ngenechen as fourfold divine being -- old man, old woman, young man, young woman -- is the Mapuche sacred tradition's most original philosophical contribution to the Haligrig library: the understanding that the divine is not a singular power but a balance of complementary principles, and that human community life at its best reflects this divine community. The Haligrig Tetralty's four dimensions (Feeling, Thinking, Speaking, Doing) are a similar recognition: the divine is not one thing but four things in dynamic balance.

The Wenu Mapu -- The Upper World

The Wenu Mapu is the upper world of Mapuche cosmology -- the realm of Ngenechen, the beneficial pillanes (ancestral spirits of great chiefs and machi), and the sacred forces that sustain the earth below. The Wenu Mapu is not a distant afterlife destination but an active dimension of the present cosmos, accessible to the machi through trance during ceremony and communicating with the human world through dreams, natural signs, and the specific phenomena that the Mapuche sacred tradition knows how to read. The sun, the moon, and the stars are specific sacred beings of the Wenu Mapu -- each with their own character, their own associations, and their own specific relationship with the human world below.

The Wekufu -- Dark Forces and Spiritual Danger

The wekufu are the dangerous spiritual forces of the Mapuche sacred world -- entities that cause illness, misfortune, and disruption. They may be sent by a kalku (a practitioner working harmful magic) or may arise naturally from the disruption of the sacred order. The wekufu are not evil in an absolute sense -- they are forces operating in the wrong place, in the wrong relationship with the human community. The machi's healing work involves identifying and expelling wekufu from the bodies of those they have afflicted. The relationship between the machi (the healer) and the kalku (the harmful practitioner) is the

Mapuche tradition's expression of the universal shamanic understanding that the same sacred power that heals can also harm, depending entirely on the intention and orientation of the practitioner.

Ixofill Mogen -- The Sacredness of All Living Things

Ixofill Mogen is the Mapuche concept that most directly parallels the Lakota Mitakuye Oyasin (All My Relations) and the Haligric understanding of the sacred web of life. The phrase translates approximately as all living things or the totality of living beings -- but in the Mapuche sacred framework, it is not merely a description but a declaration of sacred relationship. Every living being (plants, animals, water, earth, wind) is not merely a resource or a backdrop to human life but a member of the same sacred community that human beings belong to, with its own ngen (guardian spirit), its own sacred character, and its own claim on human respect and reciprocity.

Every significant element of the natural world -- rivers, mountains, specific trees, animals -- is governed by a ngen. The ngen of a river must be acknowledged before entering it; the ngen of a tree must be addressed before cutting it. This is the practical expression of Ixofill Mogen operating in daily life. The contemporary Mapuche political movement's resistance to the logging industry, to hydroelectric dam projects, and to mining in Mapuche territory is not merely political activism -- it is the direct practical expression of Ixofill Mogen. When Mapuche activists block logging operations, they are defending the ngen of specific forests. When they resist dam construction, they are protecting the ngen of specific rivers. The sacred and the political are completely integrated.

HALIGRIC LENS: Ixofill Mogen is the Mapuche articulation of what Haligrity holds as foundational -- that the divine is not separate from the living world but is the living world, that every being is a vessel of sacred presence, and that the practitioner's primary obligation is to maintain right relationship with all members of the sacred community. Mitakuye Oyasin in Mapudungun.

The Machi -- The Female Sacred Specialist

The machi is the central sacred specialist of the Mapuche tradition -- the healer, the spiritual mediator between the human and spirit worlds, the keeper of sacred plant knowledge, and the primary conductor of the major Mapuche ceremonies. In most Mapuche communities, the machi role is predominantly female -- making the Mapuche machi tradition one of the world's most important examples of female spiritual authority and power, alongside the Korean mudang tradition and the Ga Woyei tradition.

The machi's responsibilities encompass healing (diagnosing and treating illness through spiritual means and plant medicine), ceremony (conducting the machitun healing ceremony and participating in the great community ceremonies), divination (reading the spiritual dimension of situations to provide guidance), and protection (defending the community against wekufu and other harmful forces). Male machi also exist in the tradition. Male machi traditionally adopt specific feminine expressions in dress and behavior -- the machi role is understood as requiring a specific sacred gender quality that transcends ordinary male/female categories. The machi occupies one of the most important positions in Mapuche community life -- more important than political authority in matters of sacred concern.

How a Machi Is Called -- The Pewma (Sacred Dream)

The machi role is not chosen -- it is called. The calling comes through pewma (sacred dreams) or through illness that is identified by an experienced machi as the spirits' claim on the person. The calling cannot be refused without serious consequences -- the person who resists the machi calling may experience worsening illness, misfortune, or spiritual crisis

until they accept the role. The specific dream content that signals a machi calling includes: encounters with the spirit world in the dream state, visions of the rewe (the sacred carved pole), and experiences of healing others in the dream. The recognition of the calling by an established machi -- through consultation with the spirit world -- is essential to confirming it as genuine.

Machi Initiation -- Step-by-Step

Step 1 -- Recognition: An established machi confirms the calling through consultation with the spirit world.

Step 2 -- Preparation: The candidate undergoes learning under the established machi's guidance -- sacred plant knowledge, sacred songs (tayul), ceremony forms, and protocols for working with the spirit world.

Step 3 -- The Rewe Is Carved: The most sacred object of the machi -- the rewe, a carved wooden pole representing the axis mundi -- is carved from a specific tree (typically a canelo, the sacred tree of the Mapuche). The carving is itself a ceremony.

Step 4 -- The Datun (Initiation Ceremony): The formal initiation -- the candidate is recognized by the community as a machi, the rewe is consecrated and planted in the ground outside the machi's house, and the machi enters the trance state for the first time in her role, climbing the rewe to communicate with the spirit world. The community gathers. Ceremonial kultrun drumming accompanies the initiation.

Step 5 -- The First Ascent of the Rewe: The climax of the initiation -- the newly initiated machi climbs the rewe while in trance, demonstrating the ability to move between worlds. Senior machi support her through this first ascent.

Step 6 -- The Recognition: The community formally recognizes the new machi. From this point she carries the responsibilities of the role.

The Machi's Tools -- Kultrun, Rewe, and Sacred Plants

The machi works with three primary sacred tools. The rewe: the carved wooden pole planted outside the machi's house, representing the axis mundi and the machi's specific path between the worlds. Each rewe is unique to the machi who commissioned it. The sacred plants: an extensive botanical knowledge of medicinal and sacred plants of the Mapuche territory. The Mapuche pharmacopoeia is one of the most comprehensive in South American Indigenous tradition, including treatments for conditions across the physical, spiritual, and psychological spectrum. The kultrun: the sacred drum that is the machi's most important ceremonial instrument.

The Kultrun -- The Sacred Drum, Complete Treatment

The kultrun is a single-headed frame drum -- a shallow bowl shape made from a carved wooden base, with a skin stretched across the top and tied underneath, approximately 35-50 cm in diameter and played with a single padded stick. What is inside the kultrun: the kultrun is not merely a drum -- it is a sacred vessel. Sealed inside when it is made are specific sacred objects that the machi places there: seeds from important plants, small stones from sacred locations, herbs with specific healing properties, and sometimes specific sacred objects associated with the machi's personal spirit relationship. These contents are the kultrun's sacred core.

The kultrun's painted face: the head of the kultrun is painted with a specific design that encodes the Mapuche cosmological system -- four quadrants representing the four directions and the fourfold nature of Ngenechen (old man, old woman, young man, young woman), with specific additional symbols particular to each machi's sacred relationships. The kultrun's

painted face is simultaneously a map of the cosmos and the machi's personal sacred signature. The kultrun's sound as sacred technology: the kultrun's sound in ceremony is not accompaniment -- it is the primary active medium through which the machi enters and maintains the trance state, calls the spirits, and directs the healing energy. Different rhythmic patterns call different spirits and serve different ceremonial functions.

The Machitun -- The Healing Ceremony, Step-by-Step

The machitun is the Mapuche healing ceremony -- conducted by the machi when a member of the community is suffering from illness that has a spiritual component.

Preparation: The machi is consulted about the patient's condition. Through divination and spirit contacts, she determines the nature of the illness. The machi undergoes specific preparatory practices -- fasting, prayer, and specific plant preparations. The community is notified and gathers.

Step 1 -- The Opening Songs (Tayul): The machi begins with her personal sacred songs -- specific to her spirit relationships -- that open communication with the spirit world and call her spirit allies.

Step 2 -- The Kultrun Begins: The kultrun's specific healing rhythms activate the sacred space and begin the machi's transition toward trance.

Step 3 -- The Trance State (Kuymi): The machi enters the kuymi -- the specific altered state through which she directly perceives the spiritual dimension of the patient's illness.

Step 4 -- The Diagnosis in the Spirit World: In the kuymi, the machi directly perceives what is causing the patient's illness -- the specific wekufu, the specific ngen that has been offended.

Step 5 -- The Extraction: If the illness is caused by wekufu that have entered the patient's body, the machi performs specific extractive techniques to remove the harmful presence.

Step 6 -- The Plant Medicine: The machi applies specific sacred plant preparations addressing the physical dimensions of the illness simultaneously.

Step 7 -- The Restoration: Having removed what should not be present, the machi works to restore what should be there -- calling back the patient's pullu (life force) if it has been frightened away.

Step 8 -- The Closing: Specific closing songs and drumming formally conclude the healing work and return the ceremonial space to ordinary consciousness.

The Ngillatun -- The Great Community Ceremony, Step-by-Step

The Ngillatun (also spelled Nguillatun) is the great collective ceremony of the Mapuche -- the most important ceremony in the sacred calendar, conducted by a community or group of communities to maintain right relationship with Ngenechen, to express gratitude for abundance, and to petition for the community's wellbeing. Held every one to four years in spring or early summer, lasting two to four days.

Preparation: Community leaders and the machi consult to determine the Ngillatun's timing. Specific animals are designated as offerings. The ceremonial ground (the ngillatun field) is prepared and oriented.

Step 1 -- The Gathering: Communities gather from surrounding areas -- the Ngillatun may involve hundreds or thousands of participants, each family grouping taking specific positions according to clan affiliations.

Step 2 -- Ceremonial Orientation: The ceremony is oriented to the east -- the direction of the rising sun and of Ngenechen's primary sacred presence.

Step 3 -- The Machi Opens: The machi begins with her sacred songs and kultrun drumming -- opening communication with the spirit world.

Step 4 -- The Prayer to Ngenechen (Ngellipun): The assembled community prays collectively to Ngenechen -- rhythmic repetition of specific sacred phrases, lifting of branches toward the sky, the raising of voices in sustained collective invocation.

Step 5 -- The Ritual Racing (Awun): Groups of men on horseback perform ritual circuits of the ceremonial ground in the sacred counterclockwise direction -- the movement representing the community's vitality.

Step 6 -- The Sacred Dances: Specific dances are performed -- including the choike purrun (the rhea dance, imitating the sacred bird), one of the most visually striking ceremonial dances in South American Indigenous tradition.

Step 7 -- The Sacrifice and Offerings: Specific animals are sacrificed and specific foods offered -- blood may be offered to the earth, specific organs offered in specific directions.

Step 8 -- The Communal Feast: The sacrificed animals are prepared and the community eats together.

Step 9 -- The Continuation: The ceremony continues across multiple days -- alternating between ceremony, prayer, dance, feast, and rest.

Step 10 -- The Closing: The machi formally closes -- thanking Ngenechen, releasing the sacred space, and marking the community's return to ordinary time.

Mapuche Sacred Cosmvision and the Four Directions

The four directions are a primary organizing principle of Mapuche sacred life -- each direction associated with specific sacred qualities, specific sacred colors, and specific sacred forces. The east (puel mapu) is the direction of Ngenechen's primary sacred presence -- the direction of the rising sun, of new beginnings, and of the most auspicious sacred orientation. Most Mapuche ceremonies are oriented to the east for this reason. The south (willi mapu) is associated with cold, with the sacred forces of winter, and with the specific challenges of survival. The west (nag mapu) is the direction of the setting sun, of completion, and of transition. The north (piku mapu) is associated with warmth and with the forces of growth. The Mapuche sacred landscape is organized around this directional framework -- the four directions mapping onto the fourfold nature of Ngenechen, with the human community at the center maintaining right relationship with all four simultaneously.

Death and Funeral Practices in Mapuche Tradition

In the Mapuche understanding, death is a transition rather than an ending -- the pullu (life force, spirit) of the deceased makes a journey to the Wenu Mapu or to the realm of the pillanes (ancestor spirits), where they continue to exist and to influence the living world. The proper conduct of the funeral ceremony is essential to supporting this transition -- an improperly conducted funeral can leave the deceased's pullu confused and potentially harmful to the living. Traditional Mapuche burial oriented the deceased toward the west (the setting sun, direction of completion and of the passage to the next state). Specific grave goods were included -- objects the person would need in the journey and in the after-life. The funeral gathering (wenxuwen) included specific songs, specific food preparation, and the specific wailing traditions that express grief while simultaneously acknowledging the sacred character of the transition. The machi plays a specific role in the funeral ceremony -- communicating with the deceased's spirit, confirming its successful transition, and providing any specific ceremonial interventions that the transition requires.

The Lonko -- Sacred Leadership

The lonko (head, chief) is the political and social leader of the Mapuche lof (community) -- a role that carries specific sacred dimensions alongside its practical functions. The lonko is not a dictator or a hereditary king -- their authority rests on community consent and on the demonstration of wisdom, courage, generosity, and right relationship with the sacred world. The lonko conducts diplomatic relations with other communities, organizes collective labor, and speaks for the community in political contexts. The relationship between the lonko (political authority) and the machi (sacred authority) is one of the most important structural features of Mapuche governance -- neither role subsumes the other, and the most effective Mapuche communities are those in which these two sources of authority work in genuine collaboration.

Contemporary Mapuche -- Land, Rights, and Cultural Survival

The Mapuche political movement -- demanding the return of ancestral lands and recognition of Mapuche political autonomy -- is one of the most significant Indigenous political movements in South America. It is ongoing and active. In Chile, the conflict centers on the Araucania, Bio-Bio, Los Rios, and Los Lagos regions, where Mapuche communities are dispossessed of lands now held by forestry corporations, and where resistance has included both legal activism and direct action against logging infrastructure. The Chilean government has repeatedly used Pinochet-era antiterrorism laws against Mapuche activists -- a practice condemned by Amnesty International, the Inter-American Court of Human Rights, and the United Nations.

In May 2025, the Presidential Commission for Peace and Understanding (established by President Gabriel Boric in June 2023) delivered a historic final report to Boric with 21 policy recommendations for strengthening Mapuche rights -- including the creation of new public agencies and the recognition of collective Indigenous rights in the constitution. Chile remains the only country in Latin America without constitutional recognition of Indigenous peoples. Critics noted that forestry companies continue working in Indigenous areas and many Mapuche activists remain in prison. In Argentina, President Milei's government declared the Mapuche Resistance Army (RAM) a terrorist organization in February 2025. The Inter-American Commission on Human Rights heard Mapuche testimony in December 2024 and issued a public statement calling on Argentina to respect Indigenous land rights. The Vaca Muerta fracking mega-project in Neuquen province -- one of the world's largest -- continues expanding through ancestral Mapuche territory. In November 2024, the International Tribunal for the Rights of Nature declared the environmental damage caused by Vaca Muerta constitutes both ecocide and ethnocide.

The machi's rewe still stands outside her house. The kultrun still sounds at the machitun. The Ngillatun still gathers communities across Mapuche territory in the sacred counterclockwise circuit. Approximately 20% of Mapuche people speak Mapudungun today; revitalization programs are active in both Chile and Argentina. The Ngillatun is now celebrated by urban Mapuche communities in Santiago, Concepcion, Temuco, and Buenos Aires as well as in the rural territory where it began. Ixofill Mogen was never a philosophy. It was always the operating principle.

The Haligrity Lens -- Ixofill Mogen and the Sacred Web of Life

The Mapuche tradition offers Haligrity the most explicitly articulated available South American model of the sacred web of life -- Ixofill Mogen as the operating cosmological principle that every being is sacred, every being has its guardian spirit, and the human community's primary obligation is right relationship with the entire living community it belongs to. The machi as a model of sacred embodiment: the machi's work is the Haligrity Tetralty operating at full ceremonial intensity -- Feeling in the trance state where the machi's ordinary self recedes and the spirit's knowledge fills her awareness; Thinking in the specific diagnostic precision that identifies what wekufu is present and what remedy is

required; Speaking in the tayul (sacred songs) that open and close the ceremony and direct the healing energy; Doing in the physical performance of the machitun that is simultaneously ceremony, medicine, and embodied sacred act.

The machi climbs the rewe in trance -- the carved pole that is the axis mundi, the specific bridge between the human world and the spirit world above. The kultrun's rhythm changes and the spirit allies arrive. The patient's wekufu is identified and expelled. The community rides the counterclockwise circuit of the ceremonial ground. The collective voice rises toward Ngenechen in the east. This is a people who stopped both the Inca Empire and three centuries of Spanish colonization. They did it with the kultrun still sounding. Ixofill Mogen. Grand Rising.